already become a colony or a built-up structure. Encroachment over the years on vacant defence land has increased manifold," he says.

Ferozepur and Other Scams

The Jahaz Ground fraud came to light in 2008 when five individuals filed a civil suit seeking possession of the 15-acre airfield that they claimed to have 'bought' in 1997 and occupied it thereafter, alleging that the army forcibly evicted them from it in 2006. In 1997, a woman reportedly sold the land to the five using a General Power of Attorney (GPA) executed by her brother-in-law. However, he had died in 1991, rendering the GPA invalid at the time of the sale. The issue goes back to 1964, when a scheme was launched to appoint crop managers on vacant cantonment lands to boost foodgrain production, and two residents were appointed for the 15-acre plot. Later, it was handed back to the army. Though revenue records clearly mention the army as the owner, the then sub-registrar allegedly ignored them and forged documents while registering the sale deed in 1997. The army has physical control of the plot, while operational and administrative control lies with the IAF's Halwara air base in Ludhiana. In response to the civil suit, the IAF reported the matter to the financial commissioner of revenue and the deputy commissioner, demanding action against the revenue officials. No action was taken, prompting Col. Antal's letter seeking a CBI probe.

Similarly, the CBI in 2019 registered a case of alleged encroachment of land worth crores of rupees by hotel owners in the sensitive Badami Bagh cantonment in Srinagar. The agency has booked former officers of the cantonment board and others. It claimed officials allegedly helped private individuals to grab defence land. The matter is still in the courts.

In 2018, senior BJP leader Nirmal Singh was accused of encroaching some 12 acres of vacant army land adjacent to the Nagrota army base in Jammu. The land was later sold to a builder. Despite the Defence Works Act prohibiting any construction within 500 metres and 200 metres of military installations for commercial and residential purposes, respectively, Singh's actions went unchecked, forcing the army to complain to the state governor. This matter, too, is in the courts. In the Sunjuwan military station, also in Jammu, over 500 homes and commercial establishments have been set up within the station's walls, flouting defence laws and compromising security.

The other prominent scams that shook public trust in the military's ability to safeguard its assets include the Adarsh Housing Society scandal (2010) in Mumbai where top military officials and politicians colluded to illegally acquire flats meant for Kargil war widows and MoD officials at below market rates; the Sukna land scam (2008), which involved army officers who conspired to transfer military land next to 33 Corps headquarters in Siliguri, West Bengal, to private developers; and the

A NEFARIOUS HISTORY

Aided by both systemic corruption and a culture of indifference in the forces, vacant defence land worth crores has been grabbed over the decades. Here are some of the prominent scams that have been uncovered



BHASKAR PAUL

Adarsh Housing scam (2010)

Area: *31-storey building on 3837.57 sq. mtrs*

Top military officials, politicians and bureaucrats allegedly colluded to illegally acquire flats meant for Kargil war widows and MoD officials at below market rates in the Adarsh Housing Society in Mumbai. The trial is on in courts

Sukna land scam (2008)

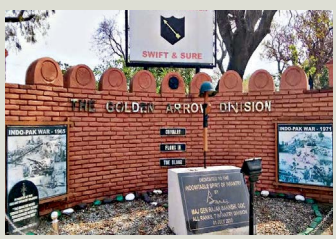
Area: *71 acres*

Senior military officials were accused of facilitating the transfer of defense land to private developers belonging to the Army's Sukna Cantonment area near Siliguri, West Bengal. Involved senior army officers found guilty

Jahaz Ground, Ferozpur (2008)

Area: *15 acres*

The plot, outside the Ferozepur cantonment, Punjab, originally used as an emergency airfield by the IAF, was sold off to private entities through alleged forgery of documents by revenue officials. No action taken on complaint by army and IAF, CBI probe demanded in 2024



Pune land scam (2011)

Area: *0.96 acres*

Originally earmarked for military use, the land in Pune cantonment was sold to a private builder with the complicity of the local authorities and military personnel, leading to a CBI probe. Senior army officer acquitted by CBI; probe is on